

Lab: Moving from the Inside Out

Objective

Explore action as an embodied process that begins with inner impulse and unfolds through the body's conversation with the environment. This lab reveals how movement is not the execution of a command but the body's way of reducing prediction error in real time.

Prerequisites

- A space where you can move freely for 25 minutes (at least arm's reach in all directions)
- Comfortable clothing
- No prior movement training required

Part 1: The Impulse Before the Movement (5 minutes)

Stand in a relaxed position with eyes closed. Do not decide to move. Instead, wait for the body to want to move. It might take 30 seconds, or two minutes. Something will shift -- a sway, an urge to stretch, a pull in one direction.

When the impulse arrives, follow it. Let the movement be small at first. Do not choreograph; let the body lead.

After three minutes of following impulses, pause and stand still again.

Write your response here

(What was the first impulse? Where in your body did it begin? What was the quality of movement that followed -- was it smooth, jerky, slow, sudden?)

Part 2: Affordances in the Room (5 minutes)

Open your eyes and look around your space. Gibson's ecological psychology tells us that we do not see objects neutrally -- we see what they afford our body. A chair affords sitting; a table edge affords resting hands; a doorway affords passing through.

1. Walk slowly around your space. Notice what each surface, edge, and object invites your body to do.
2. Follow at least three affordances: sit on something, lean against something, pick something up.
3. For each interaction, notice: the body already knew how to do this before you thought about it. The shape of the object and the shape of your body together create the action.

This is morphological computation -- the body's physical form does much of the computational work of action.

Write your response here

(List three affordances you noticed. For each, describe how the object's shape and your body's shape worked together.)

Part 3: Effortful Versus Flowing Action (7 minutes)

1. **Effortful:** Reach for an object in an awkward way -- with the wrong hand, from a strange angle, while off-balance. Notice the effort, the strain, the heightened attention.
2. **Flowing:** Now reach for the same object in the most natural way. Notice the ease, the lack of conscious effort, the automaticity.
3. **Novel:** Pick up the object using a part of your body you would not normally use (the back of your hand, your forearm, your elbow). Notice the novelty and the heightened prediction error.

In Active Inference, effortful action corresponds to high prediction error -- the body's model does not have a well-practiced policy for this movement. Flowing action corresponds to low prediction error -- the body's model accurately predicts the sensory consequences of its movement.

Write your response here

(Compare the felt quality of effortful, flowing, and novel action. What does effort feel like in the body? What does flow feel like?)

Part 4: Expressing Inner States (5 minutes)

1. Check in with your current emotional or energetic state. Without words, let your body express this state through movement. It might be slow and heavy, or quick and light, or tense and contained.
2. Now deliberately shift your movement to the opposite quality. If you were slow, move fast. If you were contracted, expand.
3. Notice: does changing the movement change the inner state? In Active Inference, action can change internal predictions by changing the sensory input the body receives from its own movement.

Write your response here

(What was your initial state? What happened when you expressed it through movement? What happened when you moved in the opposite way?)

Part 5: Reflection

Write your response here

(How does this lab change your understanding of action? Is action something you do, or something that unfolds through you?)

Reflection Table

Action Dimension	What I Felt	Active Inference Connection
Pre-movement impulse		Motor prediction before enactment
Affordances		Environment-body coupling
Effort vs. flow		Prediction error magnitude
Expression through movement		Action as interoceptive regulation
Body leading mind		Motor inference shaping belief